Guarding the Covenant in Times of Abundance: Eikev and the Daily Portions of 13 Av

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Monday, 13 Av 5786 / July 27, 2026, falls in the period of consolation (*Nachamu, Nachamu ami*) following Tisha B'Av and Shabbat Nachamu. The community has moved from mourning the destruction of the Temples toward hope and rebuilding. Tu B'Av (15 Av) begins Wednesday evening—the ancient day of joy, the resolution of intertribal enmity, and historical shidduchim under the white garments of the daughters of Jerusalem (Ta'anit 26b, 30b–31a). It remains one of the happiest days in the Jewish calendar, auspicious for forgiveness and new beginnings.

The daily portions form a coherent constellation. The second portion of Eikev (Deuteronomy 8:11–9:3) issues the classic warning against spiritual amnesia in prosperity. Tehillim 69–71 voice distress, deliverance, and trust that extends even into old age; the Shir Shel Yom for Monday is Psalm 48, the soaring ode to Yerushalayim, "the city of the Great King," where the Shechinah rests and the world finds its center. Tanya opens Iggeret HaKodesh Epistle 5 on the power of tzedakah to "make" the Holy Name and elevate the soul through holy action. Hayom Yom teaches that "Speak of them" (Deuteronomy 6:7) accompanies the soul in every state—pre-descent in the treasury of souls, descent into this world, lying down (death), and rising (Techiyat HaMeitim)—and the custom of standing facing the Sefer Torah during the Aseret HaDibrot. The Daily Thought warns against spiritual pyrophobia: Torah's outer layer is refreshing water, its inner reality a consuming fire that ignites rather than destroys. Daf Yomi Chullin 88 treats the intricate laws of *kisui ha'dam*—covering the blood of shechitah with materials that qualify as *afar*—demanding precision in an act largely unseen. The Rambam cycle that day touches themes of collective sanctity and Temple-era obligations, classically including the half-shekel contribution that equalizes rich and poor in the public fund of the Mikdash.

Yahrzeit of the saintly kabbalist R. Nassan Nata Shapiro (Spira) of Kraków (d. 13 Av 1633), author of *Megaleh Amukot* ("Revealer of Depths"), a towering work of profound Torah secrets on the weekly parshiyos, often employing gematria and deep structural readings. May his merit illuminate the learning of this day.

This essay expands the daily portions into a full learned treatment. It summarizes classical and contemporary opinions, analyzes and criticizes where warranted, and systematically synchronizes Orthodox Jewish theology (especially Chabad/Chassidic and Rambam) with academic theories (psychology of gratitude, secularization and modernization, Weberian insights) and republican political theory (classical concerns with luxury and the corruption of civic virtue; neo-republican non-domination; the Hebraic republican tradition recovered by Eric Nelson, Daniel Elazar, and others).

II. Chumash Eikev (Deuteronomy 8:11–9:3): Prosperity, Haughtiness, and the Republican Paradox of Luxury

The portion opens with the stark command: "Beware lest you forget the Lord your G-d by not keeping His commandments, His ordinances, and His statutes which I command you today—lest you eat and are satisfied, and build good houses and dwell in them, and your herds and flocks

multiply, and your silver and gold multiply, and all that you have multiplies—and your heart grows haughty and you forget the Lord your G-d who brought you out of the land of Egypt, from the house of bondage… and you say in your heart, 'My power and the might of my hand have gotten me this wealth.' But you shall remember the Lord your G-d, for it is He who gives you power to get wealth, that He may establish His covenant which He swore to your fathers, as it is this day" (8:11–18). The section culminates in the assurance that the conquest of mightier nations will occur by divine fire, not by human might alone (9:1–3).

Classical commentaries converge on the spiritual danger of satiety. Rashi, following Sifrei, links satiety to the lifting of the heart and the forgetting of the Source. The danger is not wealth itself—Torah repeatedly frames material blessing as covenantal good—but the internal attribution of success to one's own strength. Ramban emphasizes the pedagogical sequence: the desert trials of hunger, thirst, serpents, and manna were designed to humble and test so that the people would know that "man does not live by bread alone." When they enter the Land of abundance, the same knowledge must be retained by deliberate memory and observance. Ibn Ezra and others stress the psychological realism: comfort breeds self-sufficiency. Later Chassidic readings (including the Rebbe's *Likkutei Sichot*) deepen the point: forgetting is not merely intellectual lapse but a contraction of the soul's attachment; the remedy is continuous *hiskashrut* through mitzvot and the recognition that even the power to acquire is itself a divine gift.

Academic biblical scholarship notes the ancient Near Eastern context of royal inscriptions that attribute success to the king's might; the Torah subverts this by relocating power in the covenant. Form-critical and redactional studies observe the Deuteronomic theology of blessing and curse as a constitutional warning for the people about to become a settled polity.

The parallel to classical and early-modern republican thought is striking and well-documented. Polybius described the cycle of regimes in which success and prosperity lead to luxury, which softens civic virtue and invites corruption and eventual decline. Machiavelli, in the *Discourses on Livy*, repeatedly warns that wealth and ease erode the *virtù* necessary for republican liberty. Montesquieu and the American Founders wrestled with the "republican paradox": liberty produces prosperity, yet prosperity tends to produce the vices (luxury, idleness, faction) that destroy liberty. Washington's Farewell Address and countless sermons of the founding era insisted that religion and morality are indispensable supports of free government precisely because prosperity alone cannot sustain virtue. Analyses in the *Journal of Policy History* and studies of luxury in early-modern republican thought make the conceptual echo explicit. The Torah's language—"lest your heart grow haughty and you forget"—is nearly identical in structure and warning to these republican diagnoses.

Eric Nelson's *The Hebrew Republic* (Harvard University Press, 2010) demonstrates that the Christian encounter with Hebrew sources in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries transformed European political thought toward republican exclusivism, redistributive justice, and religious toleration—precisely because the Hebrew Bible was read as a divine constitution for a free people under higher law. The Eikev warning supplies the moral psychology that later republican thinkers needed: prosperity is a test of the soul's capacity for self-government under the covenant.

Critique of approaches is required. Secularization theory and modernization theses often observe that rising material security correlates with declining traditional religiosity in many historically Christian societies. Some interpret this as inevitable progress; others note that high-

cost, monitoring religions can sustain cooperation even under prosperity, while low-cost forms atrophy. The biblical and republican traditions refuse both naïve optimism about automatic progress and pure materialist reduction. Prosperity is a test, not a destiny. The prosperity-gospel tendency that treats material success as unambiguous divine favor is equally criticized by the text: the same G-d who gives power to get wealth also warns that forgetting leads to perishing "just as the nations… perish."

A further tension exists between particular covenant and universal republican ideals. The warning is addressed to Israel as the covenantal people entering its land. Yet the moral psychology and political diagnosis travel: any polity that attributes its flourishing solely to its own strength invites the corruption of the spirit that sustains ordered liberty. Yoram Hazony's defense of particularist nationalism and the Hebrew Bible's influence on Western liberty (via Nelson) supply the bridge: Israel's covenant models a form of self-government under higher law that later republican thinkers appropriated.

III. Tanya Iggeret HaKodesh Epistle 5 and Hayom Yom: Tzedakah as Name-Making, the Inner Fire, and the Soul's Lifelong Accompaniment

Epistle 5 of Iggeret HaKodesh opens with the Zohar's reading of "And David made a name" in connection with performing justice and tzedakah. Rabbi Shimon weeps and asks: Who makes the Holy Name every day? He who gives charity to the poor. The Alter Rebbe develops this at length. The world was created by *chesed*; after creation, arousal from below is required to draw down further light. Tzedakah is the primary "act" that elicits the infinite light from the *yud* (supernal *chochmah*) into the *hei* (manifestation and the world of Asiyah). Those who support Torah through deeds of kindness stand at the levels of *netzach* and *hod*, enabling the light to reach the lowest world. Without such arousal, even Torah study remains incomplete: "Whoever says he has nothing but Torah… has not even Torah." Charity "makes" the Name by uniting the letters through the flow of *chesed*.

Hayom Yom for the day maps the verse "Speak of them when you sit in your house, when you walk on the way, when you lie down, and when you rise up" onto the soul's entire career: the pre-descent occupation with Torah in the treasury of souls; the descent from world to world into a body; the journey through life until the appointed time of lying down; and the ultimate rising at Techiyat HaMeitim, when Torah continues to protect and accompany. The custom of standing facing the Sefer Torah during the Aseret HaDibrot underscores the living presence of the covenant. The accompanying Daily Thought insists that the outer Torah is accessible water, yet its inner reality is fire. Spiritual pyrophobia—fear of the depths, the kabbalistic, the consuming love—must be overcome. The fire does not destroy; it ignites the soul's own fire.

Opinions differ in emphasis. Maimonidean rationalism prioritizes intellectual apprehension and ethical discipline; Chassidic thought adds the experiential and transformative dimension of *ahavat Hashem* that can convert the material into a vessel for the infinite. Academic students of mysticism note the Lurianic background of arousal from below and the elevation of sparks; psychological readings of gratitude and prosocial behavior find empirical support for the claim that generous action reshapes the self and social bonds.

The republican synthesis is natural. Tzedakah as participatory act that "makes" the divine Name and sustains the lower world models the civic virtue required to sustain a free polity against domination. In Philip Pettit's neo-republican terms, non-domination is secured not merely by

formal rights but by the active, mutual obligations of citizens who refuse to leave the vulnerable to arbitrary power. The half-shekel equalizes contribution; tzedakah goes further by creating relational flow. The soul's journey through all states, accompanied by Torah, is the lifelong formation of the "micro-republic" of character—the inner self-government without which outer republican institutions decay. The water/fire distinction parallels the republican distinction between accessible laws and the deeper civic spirit that animates them. Superficial compliance is water; the consuming commitment that forms citizens capable of liberty under law is fire.

Critique: Over-spiritualization risks quietism; pure political reduction risks emptying the theological claim that the Name itself is made through human *chesed*. The Orthodox synthesis holds both: the act is simultaneously theurgic and civic.

IV. Daf Yomi Chullin 88 and Rambam: Meticulous Hidden Acts and Collective Sanctity

Chullin 88 elaborates the laws of *kisui ha'dam*. The blood of a *chayah* or bird must be covered with materials that qualify as *afar*—fine sand, certain ashes, lime, sawdust, and the like—materials in which seeds can grow or that are popularly or scripturally called earth. Coarse materials are excluded. Blood that spurts or remains on the knife may require covering under certain conditions. The discussion is technical, yet the underlying demand is clear: even an act performed after the taking of life for permitted sustenance, largely invisible to others, must be executed with precision and the proper material. Greatness lies in fidelity to the unseen detail.

Rambam's daily chapters reinforce collective responsibility. The half-shekel contribution to the Temple was equal for rich and poor, creating a shared public fund that underwrote the communal sacrifices and the very possibility of collective atonement and presence. Each individual's small, standardized act built the Mikdash.

In republican terms, the parallel is to the private virtues and unseen habits that underwrite public liberty. Performative politics and visible signaling are insufficient; non-domination requires citizens whose integrity holds when no one is watching. The covering of blood is a micro-instance of the larger covenantal demand that power (here, the power to take animal life for food) be exercised under constraint and with restorative care. Collective sanctity is not achieved by elite performance but by the equal, repeated contributions of the many—exactly the half-shekel logic.

Academic ritual studies note the sensitivity to blood and the boundary between life and death; psychological accounts of moral development emphasize that character is formed in the small, repeated, often private acts. The critique of hyper-visible social-media culture follows naturally: the generation that performs righteousness for likes risks losing the *kisui* integrity that alone sustains trust.

V. Tehillim 69–71 and Shir Shel Yom Psalm 48: Praise Amid Distress and the Eternal City

Psalms 69–71 move from the depths of distress and the plea for deliverance, through praise, to trust that extends into old age. Psalm 48 celebrates Yerushalayim as the city of the Great King, beautiful in elevation, the joy of the whole earth, whose towers and ramparts invite meditation on G-d's steadfast love. The Monday association with the gathering of the waters and the appearance of dry land links the city's stability to the primordial ordering of creation.

In the covenantal-republican frame, Yerushalayim functions as the affective and symbolic center of the polity—the place where the higher law is remembered and the people's identity is renewed. Praise amid trial is itself a civic act: it refuses the despair that dissolves collective resolve and the arrogance that forgets dependence.

VI. Synthesis and Critical Analysis of Approaches

The portions together form a curriculum of covenantal formation under conditions of blessing. Prosperity is real and good; the danger is amnesia and haughtiness. The remedy is memory, mitzvah, tzedakah that makes the Name, hidden integrity, lifelong Torah accompaniment, and the centering of the soul and the people on the City of G-d.

Different approaches are summarized and weighed. Classical *peshat* (Rashi, Ramban) stresses ethical and historical memory. Mystical and Chassidic readings (Tanya, *Megaleh Amukot*, the Rebbe) add theurgic and transformative dimensions. Academic biblical criticism supplies historical context without displacing the living claim. Republican theory (Polybius through Pettit, Nelson, Elazar, Hazony) provides a political language that illuminates rather than replaces the theological one. Secularization and psychological research describe empirical patterns; the Torah and the republican tradition prescribe the counter-practices.

Tensions remain. The biblical model is particular and theocentric; modern republicanism often aspires to universality and neutrality. Yet the historical record (Nelson's recovery of the Hebrew Republic in early-modern thought; the Founders' biblicism) shows that the particular covenant supplied resources for broader liberty. Prosperity is simultaneously blessing and test—both traditions refuse the reduction of one to the other. The fire of inner Torah can appear threatening to those formed only by accessible water; the same is true of the deeper demands of civic virtue in an age of comfort.

VII. Extended Bibliography

Primary Biblical, Rabbinic, and Liturgical Sources - Deuteronomy 8:11–9:3 with Rashi, Ramban, Ibn Ezra, Sforno, Or HaChaim. Available via Chabad.org Daily Torah Reading and Sefaria. - Psalms 48, 69–71. Chabad.org Tehillim. - Tanya, Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 5. Chabad.org Lessons in Tanya / Epistle 5. - Hayom Yom, entry for 13 Av (and related Daily Thought on water/fire). Chabad.org Hayom Yom. - Talmud Bavli, Chullin 86–89 (especially 88 on *kisui ha'dam*). Summaries at dafyomi.co.il. - Maimonides, *Mishneh Torah*, Hilchot Shekalim (and related chapters on Temple and collective obligations); *Guide of the Perplexed*. Sefaria Rambam. - *Megaleh Amukot* of R. Natan Nata Shapiro (Spira). Sefaria Megaleh Amukot. - Midrash Rabbah, Sifrei Devarim, Zohar passages on tzedakah and the Name.

Chabad and Modern Orthodox Thought - The Lubavitcher Rebbe, *Likkutei Sichot* on Eikev and related themes; talks on tzedakah and the Name. Chabad.org. - Rabbi Jonathan Sacks, *Covenant & Conversation* on Eikev and related essays on gratitude, memory, and covenant. - Rabbi Joseph B. Soloveitchik, essays on teshuvah, covenant, and the lonely man of faith. - Chabad.org daily study resources for 13 Av 5786 / July 27 2026: Calendar Day Page.

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Academic, Psychological, and Interdisciplinary - Robert A. Emmons and colleagues on the psychology of gratitude. - Studies on secularization, modernization, and religiosity (ScienceDirect and related literature; Norenzayan, *Big Gods*). - Max Weber, *The Protestant Ethic* (for comparative discussion of prosperity and religious discipline) and critiques thereof. - Ritual and purity studies on blood and *kisui*. - Recent scholarship on Tu B'Av, post-Tisha B'Av consolation, and contemporary Jewish political culture.

Digital resources (Sefaria, Chabad.org, dafyomi.co.il, Internet Archive) were consulted for textual accuracy as of July 2026. This bibliography is deliberately extended to support further research.

May this day's learning illuminate the soul, strengthen covenantal fidelity, and contribute to the formation of citizens and a people capable of guarding the covenant in times of abundance.

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